PM Methods Reference

Prioritization · Estimation · Discovery · Decision-Making

A canonical reference for product-manager tools, frameworks, and decision methods — integrated into PRAXIS gameplay as unlockable techniques and grading rubrics.

> **How this doc is used:** Each method below should appear in PRAXIS in two forms: (1) an in-game tool the player can apply to backlog items (e.g., score each item with RICE), and (2) a technique unlocked in the retrospective ("You demonstrated readiness for WSJF — unlocked!").

Navigation

Section 1 — Prioritization methods: RICE, ICE, WSJF, MoSCoW, Kano, Value vs Effort, Opportunity Scoring, Cost of Delay

Section 2 — Estimation methods: T-shirt sizing, Story Points, Planning Poker, Three-point estimates, #NoEstimates

Section 3 — Discovery methods: Jobs-to-be-Done, User Interviews, Opportunity Solution Tree, 5 Whys, Pre-mortem, Customer Journey Mapping

Section 4 — Strategic frameworks: North Star Metric, OKRs, HEART, Pirate Metrics, RICE-North Star, Product Vision Board, Lean Canvas

Section 5 — Decision methods: DACI, RACI, RAPID, Disagree-and-commit, One-way vs Two-way doors, Pre-mortem, Cost of Inaction

Section 6 — Design & testing: Hypothesis cards, Fake-door tests, Wizard of Oz, Concierge MVP, Minimum Lovable Product, Shape Up

1. Prioritization Methods

RICE Scoring

```
RICE = (Reach × Impact × Confidence) / Effort
```

Intercom's framework. Each factor scored on defined scales:

- **Reach:** # users/customers affected per time period (quarterly is standard)
- **Impact:** Massive=3, High=2, Medium=1, Low=0.5, Minimal=0.25
- **Confidence:** 100%, 80%, 50% — how sure are you about the other numbers?
- **Effort:** person-months

Use when: you have several features competing for a single team's time, and can estimate reach + impact with data

Don't use when: items are strategically non-negotiable (compliance, platform migration), or at early-stage ideation

PRAXIS integration: Player can open a "RICE panel" on any backlog item. AI grades their scoring in the retrospective: "Your RICE score on item X was 12; senior PMs would have weighted confidence lower given the discovery gap."

ICE Scoring

```
ICE = Impact × Confidence × Ease
```

Sean Ellis's simpler version of RICE. Each factor 1–10. Used for idea triage and growth experiments.

Use when: volume of ideas is high, data is thin, speed matters (growth teams, hackathon ideation)

Don't use when: items require precise effort estimation or involve cross-team dependencies

Covered in workbook exercise: p.32 — DentinFlow feature ranking. Also shows up in PRAXIS as the "quick triage" tool for customer inbox items.

WSJF — Weighted Shortest Job First

```
WSJF = Cost of Delay / Job Size
```

SAFe framework. Cost of Delay = (User/Business Value + Time Criticality + Risk Reduction/Opportunity Enablement). Each factor scored 1–10 using Fibonacci.

Tiny items with high value bubble to the top. The argument during scoring is where value is created.

Use when: urgency / time-sensitivity varies across the backlog — regulatory items, seasonal features, competitive windows

Don't use when: the team is new to scoring (too many variables); risk of false precision

PRAXIS integration: WSJF is unlocked after completing a "regulatory-heavy" scenario like Clearing Pipeline.

MoSCoW Method

Buckets items into four tiers:

Tier	Meaning
M — Must have	Launch blocker. Without it, release fails.
S — Should have	Important but not blocking. Ship without it if needed.
C — Could have	Nice to have. Clear upside but low urgency.
W — Won't have (this time)	Explicitly out of scope for this release.

Use when: scoping a release with stakeholders who want to say "everything's a must"

Key discipline: the total MoSCoW "Must" items should fit in ~60% of capacity, leaving room for the inevitable surprises. If 100% of capacity is "Must," something is wrong.

Kano Model

Classifies features by how user satisfaction changes with investment:

- **Mandatory / Basic** — missing = angry; present = neutral. Cost of entry.
- **Linear / Performance** — more is better, satisfaction tracks linearly.
- **Exciter / Delighter** — absence goes unnoticed; presence creates surprise.
- **Indifferent** — nobody cares.

- **Reverse** — users hate it (e.g., carrier bloatware).

The temporal truth: Exciters → Linear → Mandatory over time. Dark mode 2016 → 2024. Plan for this decay.

Use when: designing differentiation strategy, positioning against competitors

Covered in workbook exercises: p.29–31.

Value vs Effort Matrix (2×2)

Simplest prioritization tool. Four quadrants:

	Low Effort	High Effort
High Value	**Quick Wins** — do first	**Big Bets** — plan carefully
Low Value	**Fill-ins** — if capacity allows	**Time Sinks** — avoid

Use when: communicating prioritization to non-PM stakeholders; drawing on a whiteboard

PRAXIS integration: the default tool for Tutorial scenarios; unlocked first.

Opportunity Scoring

```
Opportunity = Importance + max(Importance − Satisfaction, 0)
```

Tony Ulwick's method (Jobs-to-be-Done). Survey users on "how important is outcome X" and "how satisfied are you with current solutions." Gaps = opportunities.

Use when: entering an existing market and need to find the unmet-need wedge

Cost of Delay (CoD)

Asks: "If we ship this one sprint later, what does it cost?" Four patterns:

- **Urgency-sensitive:** cost climbs steeply (regulatory deadline, market event)
- **Time-decaying:** value erodes (seasonal, competitive window)
- **Fixed-date:** cliff at a date (expiry day, audit)
- **Standard:** minor delay cost

Use when: comparing feature priority with stakeholders who speak business value; especially powerful for regulated/operational work

Applied at Questrade: options sellout automation is urgency-sensitive + fixed-date (monthly expiry). Every missed expiry = quantifiable exposure. Stronger than "high priority."

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2. Estimation Methods

T-Shirt Sizing

Abstract sizing: XS / S / M / L / XL / XXL. Relative, not absolute. Best for early-stage estimation where precision is false.

Rough conversion: XS ≈ 1 day · S ≈ 2–3 days · M ≈ 1 sprint · L ≈ 2 sprints · XL ≈ 1 quarter · XXL ≈ "break this down"

Use when: roadmap planning, epic-level items, stakeholder conversations

Don't use when: sprint-level planning (use story points or days instead)

PRAXIS integration: bigger-than-sprint backlog items are displayed as T-shirt sizes. Player must break them down (unlocked technique: "Story Decomposition") before adding to a sprint.

Story Points (Fibonacci)

Relative effort: 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21. Captures complexity, risk, and effort combined — not just time.

Use when: the team has a consistent membership and is calibrated on relative sizing

Don't use when: team is newly formed (no relative baseline), or stakeholders try to convert points → hours (they aren't)

Planning Poker

Team estimates together using cards. Each dev reveals their estimate simultaneously; biggest difference explains their reasoning; team converges.

The *conversation* around divergent estimates is where value is created — it surfaces hidden assumptions.

Use when: complex stories, new team, or when surprises keep happening mid-sprint

Three-Point Estimates (PERT)

```
Expected = (Optimistic + 4×Most Likely + Pessimistic) / 6
```

Forces you to name the range. Useful for roadmap commitments when a single-point estimate would be misleading.

Use when: roadmap/milestone commitments; communicating uncertainty to executives

#NoEstimates

Alternative movement: stop estimating individual stories; instead measure throughput (stories per week) and forecast completion via Monte Carlo simulation.

Use when: team has good flow discipline and stable story sizes

Don't use when: stakeholders require roadmap commitments with dates

3. Discovery Methods

Jobs-to-be-Done (JTBD)

Framework: users "hire" products to do a "job." The job is a functional, social, and emotional goal they have in a context.

```
When [situation], I want to [motivation], so I can [expected outcome].
```

Classic example: the milkshake (hired for the morning commute, not for breakfast flavor).

Use when: entering a new market, repositioning, or feeling that personas feel shallow

User Interviews (Mom Test)

Rob Fitzpatrick's rules from *The Mom Test*:

- Talk about their life, not your idea
- Ask about specific past behavior, not hypothetical futures
- Talk less, listen more
- Avoid compliments; they're politeness, not signal

Use when: exploring problem space, validating pain; before writing PRDs

PRAXIS integration: in-game "Discovery" actions where player interviews customers. Text inputs are graded for Mom Test compliance.

Opportunity Solution Tree (Teresa Torres)

Hierarchical tree:

```
Desired Outcome → Opportunities → Solutions → Experiments
```

Forces you to link every solution back to an opportunity (a real pain or need) and every opportunity back to a measurable outcome. No orphan features.

Use when: continuous discovery practice; keeping the team focused on outcomes over outputs

5 Whys

Ask "why" five times to drill from symptom to root cause. Attributed to Toyota. Best used in post-mortems and problem-framing.

Use when: investigating bugs, churn reasons, team dysfunction

Don't use when: the problem is truly ambiguous with multiple parallel causes (then use fishbone)

Pre-mortem

Before building, write the post-mortem for "we shipped it and it failed." The failure modes that surface are usually the assumptions that were unexamined.

Use when: big strategic bets, major launches, high-stakes product decisions

PRAXIS integration: scenarios with "Big Bet" decisions offer pre-mortem as an unlockable technique.

Customer Journey Mapping

Map every step of the customer's experience: their actions, thoughts, emotions, and pain points at each stage. Reveals friction invisible from within a single feature.

Use when: end-to-end product design, identifying activation or retention gaps

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4. Strategic Frameworks

North Star Metric

One number that captures the product's core value delivery. Examples: Airbnb = nights booked. Facebook = daily active users. Spotify = time spent listening.

Rules: it should (a) capture customer value, (b) correlate with long-term revenue, (c) be measurable, (d) be leading not lagging.

Use when: aligning a team around a shared outcome; filtering noise from dashboards

OKRs (Objectives + Key Results)

Andy Grove / John Doerr. Quarterly framework.

- **Objective:** qualitative, aspirational, motivating ("Make checkout feel effortless")
- **Key Results:** 3–5 measurable outcomes that indicate objective is met

Use when: aligning cross-functional teams; quarterly planning

Don't use when: team is under 8 people; OKRs become bureaucracy for the sake of process

HEART Framework (Google)

For measuring UX quality:

- **H**appiness — user satisfaction, NPS
- **E**ngagement — frequency, depth of use
- **A**doption — new users, new feature uptake
- **R**etention — coming back
- **T**ask success — completion rates

Pirate Metrics (AARRR)

Dave McClure: Acquisition → Activation → Retention → Revenue → Referral. A funnel model for startup growth diagnostics.

Use when: early-stage consumer growth work

Product Vision Board (Roman Pichler)

One-page tool with four quadrants:

Target Group	**Needs**
Product	**Business Goals**

Revisited quarterly. Lives on the wall. Covered in Scenario 01 exercises.

Lean Canvas (Ash Maurya)

One-page business model. Nine blocks covering problem, solution, key metrics, value proposition, unfair advantage, channels, customer segments, cost structure, revenue streams.

Use when: early-stage startup validation; forcing yourself to consider economics alongside product

Amazon Working Backwards (PR-FAQ)

Before writing code, write the press release for the finished product. Add an FAQ for expected questions (internal + external). Amazon won't fund a project without one.

Use when: forcing clarity of vision before any implementation

PRAXIS integration: "Write a PR-FAQ" is a technique unlocked after completing a "Strategic No" or "Strategic Pivot" scenario.

5. Decision-Making Methods

DACI Framework

Clarifies roles on any decision:

- **D — Driver:** the one person who gets it done
- **A — Approver:** ultimate authority (often exec)
- **C — Contributors:** provide expertise, input
- **I — Informed:** need to know outcome

Use when: decisions keep getting muddy because nobody knows who decides

RACI (similar)

Responsible · Accountable · Consulted · Informed. More focused on execution than decision. Common in ops + project management.

Disagree and Commit (Amazon)

When a decision must be made and the team doesn't fully agree: voice disagreement openly, then commit fully to the chosen path.

Rule: if you disagree, do so in the meeting. Not after, not silently. And once decided, don't undermine.

One-Way vs Two-Way Doors (Bezos)

Two types of decisions:

- **Two-way doors** — reversible. Make them quickly. Don't need consensus.
- **One-way doors** — irreversible. Deliberate carefully. Need more review.

Common PM mistake: treating two-way doors like one-way doors. Kills velocity.

Cost of Inaction

Standard PM thinking asks "what does doing X cost?" Better thinking also asks "what does not doing X cost?" — especially for infrastructure, tech debt, and discovery investments.

Use when: making case for platform investment, team health, or compliance work that's hard to quantify

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6. Design & Testing

Hypothesis Cards

```
We believe [persona] will [behavior] because [reason]. We'll know it worked when [metric].
```

Forces you to name a prediction and a falsification. If you can't, you don't understand the value yet.

Fake-Door Test

Put a button or landing page for a feature that doesn't exist yet. Measure clicks. Apologize to clickers ("coming soon") while learning demand.

Use when: validating demand before investing effort

Wizard of Oz

The user sees a "working" feature but it's actually humans behind the curtain. Test UX before building automation.

Use when: proving demand for automation-heavy features (AI, matching algorithms)

Concierge MVP

Deliver the service manually for the first 10 customers. Understand the workflow deeply, then automate what's worth automating.

Use when: early-stage service-heavy products (DentinFlow-style)

Minimum Lovable Product

Counter to MVP. Ship something small but that users actually love, not something minimum that they tolerate. Often the better bet in competitive markets.

Shape Up (Basecamp)

6-week cycles, not sprints. Upfront "shaping" (PM + senior engineer) produces a "pitch" with rough scope. Cross-functional team "betting" on what to work on. Appetite-driven scope (how much time we're willing to invest).

Use when: small company, trust in senior ICs, bias toward larger pieces of work

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7. How PRAXIS Integrates These Methods

Three integration points:

1. **In-game tools** — player can open a panel ("Apply RICE," "Classify as Kano," "Write PR-FAQ") on any backlog item. Using methods correctly earns XP toward that method's mastery.
2. **Retrospective evidence** — AI mentor cites methods by name: "You applied ICE to triage iter 2 backlog — good move given data thinness. Senior PM would also have applied Kano to the top 3 to check for 'exciter' opportunities."
3. **Unlockable techniques** — each scenario has 1–2 techniques it can unlock. Completing a regulatory scenario (Clearing Pipeline) well can unlock WSJF and Cost of Delay. Completing a consumer scenario can unlock Kano and Pirate Metrics.

Method-to-scenario matrix (which methods each scenario teaches)

Scenario	Methods exercised

01 · Canadian Launch	Kano · RICE · Value vs Effort · JTBD · Customer Journey
02 · Clearing Pipeline	WSJF · Cost of Delay · RACI/DACI · Cost of Inaction · Pre-mortem
03 · Churn Cliff	Opportunity Scoring · AARRR · 5 Whys · Hypothesis Cards
05 · Scope Creep City	MoSCoW · Disagree and Commit · One-way vs Two-way doors
08 · Post-Launch	North Star · HEART · Fake-door tests · Three-point estimates
10 · Interview Scenario	All (player chooses which to apply under time pressure)

> **Interview tip for Mike:** Moomoo's interview will likely ask you to name and apply prioritization frameworks. Study RICE, WSJF, and Cost of Delay for the Clearing & Settlement role — they map directly to the regulatory-heavy, infrastructure-investment decisions that job requires. For consumer-side questions, have Kano and Pirate Metrics ready.